Achilles Heel

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Achilles Heel

by amarisllis

Summary

If he stays in here, if he *hides,* then he can’t hurt anyone else. He can’t endanger the Flame-Chase, or the city, or…

Found you. That smirk, wild and feral, yet tinged with relief and affection. All while pulling Phainon’s sword further into his stomach as Phainon cried out in shock.

…Or Mydei.

Notes

THEY MAKE ME INSANE I SWEAR TO GODDDDDDDDD. god. god. i love them so much. the end of the quest made me so SAD, like ik he'll be back and they'll be back together and happy in the end because this is exactly how cat among pigeons ended for ratiorine and everything was fine but WAITING FOR THE REST OF THE QUEST IS GONNA KILL ME I STG. anyway i had to write this down cuz break ups arent my preferred flavor of angst but man THIS SCENE.

See the end of the work for more notes

Phainon groans, limbs aching, bandages pulling at his skin and making him itch. The bedsheets are warm, sweat-slicked against his skin, yet no matter how tired he is and how he yearns to go back to sleep like he's supposed to, he can't quite manage to find rest.

Aglaea will learn that he's awake soon enough. But for now, Phainon groans, getting up and pacing the room as he pulls at the strands of his hair in frustration. Pain that isn't physical courses through him like white-hot agony, keeping him from opening the door and playing his part like he should.

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…Or Mydei.

Gods. He can't get the *noise* out of his head, the *crunch* and *squelch* of blood and bone as he felt the sword pierce Mydei's skin. Everything was so blurry, surrounded by a thick haze of red, and by the time he realized it was *Mydei* standing in front of him instead of the Abyss-damned Flame Reaver, blood was dripping through Mydei's teeth as he smiled.

Phainon hunches over, nausea curdling his stomach as he thinks about that blood-soaked grin. Gods, he really could have killed him, couldn't he? He knows that Mydei has a weak spot *somewhere* , and even though he doesn't know where it is, he could have hit it by accident, because he's stupid and naive and he *failed—*

Phainon takes a shaky breath, narrowly avoiding knocking over a vase on one of the small tables and alerting Aglaea and Tribbie that he *is* actually awake in here. The longer he sits here, the more the sight of Mydei covered in blood refuses to leave his head, the more the weight of the armor he wears feels heavy enough to make him sink into the floor.

His hands are shaking. They should be dirty, he thinks, stained with blood and guilt and failure. Soaking in thick, hazy red.

“I knew you’d be awake in here.”

Phainon jumps, narrowly fighting the urge to cry out loudly.

Mydei is standing in the open balcony door, watching him with a raised eyebrow. His arms are crossed, and Phainon notices with a jolt that he’s foregone his usual pauldron and glove. He seems almost naked without it.

Phainon swallows, eyes drifting unconsciously to the spot where his sword pierced Mydei’s body. The wound is gone, but the thick, purple bruising remains. It makes the nausea swirl again.

“Did you… climb in through the *balcony* ?” he says, to cover it up.

Mydei huffs a laugh, shrugging a little as he steps into the room and shuts the balcony door. “You wouldn’t have let me in the front door.”

No. Not when I could…

He swallows. The trial may be over, but he can’t shake the feeling that somewhere, under the surface, Nikador’s bloodlust stands ready to take him over again.

“I would have!”

Mydei’s eyebrow climbs higher, and Phainon changes the subject before he can say anything else. “So, Your Highness, come to rub it in that you had to pull me out?”

The words are biting, teasing. He hopes they’re a strong enough shield to cover up the rest of it.

Mydei’s eyes narrow as he steps closer, nearly caging Phainon in against the bed. Phainon’s blood *sings* at having him so close again like this, but the other part, the louder part, the one that’s guilty and miserable and feels like this is so much more than he deserves, feels the urge to shove him away.

“I knew it,” Mydei says, his lip curling into a small smile. “The great Deliverer is *hiding.* ”

Phainon lets out another shaky breath, internally cursing. Why, *why* must Mydei always be so gods-damned good at reading him? “I’m *resting* .”

But Mydei reaches for his hand before Phainon can shove him away, and even as Phainon’s eyes widen, he presses it firmly against the very spot where Phainon’s sword ran him through.

Seeing right through him, yet again.

Phainon sighs, blinking away a sudden rush of moisture. “You should go,” he whispers, voice suddenly gone shaky. “I—”

The words catch in his throat as Mydei presses his hand firmly against his stomach. He hisses as Phainon presses against the bruises, but golden eyes still pierce through him like knives, holding his gaze.

“Is that it?” And *oh* , his voice has gotten so much softer now, tinged with affection and sweetness that he only ever lets show when it’s the two of them and no one else. “You didn’t want to see me?”

The squelch of blood echoes in Phainon’s head, making it harder to blink the moisture away.

Mydei’s smirk softens along with his voice, melting into a tiny, *achingly* tender smile. “Guilty little hero,” he whispers, brushing Phainon’s hair back with his free hand.

Phainon feels a bit like he’s being torn in two. “I hurt you.” His voice breaks on the last word, as the first tears begin to fall. “Your blood was on my hands.”

“You know Kremnoans are no stranger to violence.” His smile doesn’t waver. “My own mother has drawn my blood more times than I could count.”

It doesn’t help; somehow, it makes Phainon feel even *more* like a monster. “I saw… Something else was in front of me, and then I *blinked* , and you were—”

The rest of the words die in his throat. Somehow it’s more damning if Phainon speaks them aloud, like it bares his shame for all the world to see.

Mydei chases him when he tries to pull away, one hand snaking around his body to press against his back and pull them chest to chest. His other hand still holds Phainon’s against the spot where the wound used to be.

“I hurt you.” Phainon chokes out the words again, unable to say anything else. Unable to deny the shame, raw, powerful, *damning* , burning him from the inside. “I wasn’t strong enough to best Nikador, and I… I *hurt you.* I’m so sorry.”

Mydei just smiles, leaning forward a little so that their foreheads are touching. It’s so jarring, the way he can just switch moods like this. Sometimes, he gets flustered so easily, unsure of the right things to say or the right path to take. One minute he’s a cocky, stubborn, fierce warrior, and the next…

The next, he’s tilting Phainon’s chin up with one finger, catching his lips in a slow kiss that Phainon doesn’t deserve.

Doesn’t he *get it* ? What if Phainon buckles under the weight again, what if he isn’t strong enough, what if next time Mydei doesn’t *heal—*

“Stop it,” he mumbles against Phainon’s mouth, nipping at his bottom lip. “I knew that you might not be yourself before I jumped into the trial to find you. We both know what Nikador is capable of.”

“But…” Phainon swallows, even as Mydei’s mouth threatens to melt his brain through his ears. “How am I supposed to just forget it? I know you’re indestructible, but I’ve never wanted to put you through more pain.”

Mydei is silent for a moment, golden eyes staring intently at him once again. Finally, he leans in again, so that when he speaks, the words brush

Phainon's lips. The hand still holding Phainon's moves it from Mydei's stomach to the small of his back, pressing his fingers at a spot along his spine.

"Right here," he whispers, so quietly that Phainon nearly misses it. "This, right here, is my weak spot. This is the only way to kill me."

Phainon's breath hitches, eyes widening. *Is he…* "Why would you tell me that?" he cries out, tears coming faster than he can blink them away. "After what I—"

"Because," Mydei says, steadfast and sure, just like he always is. "It wasn't your fault. The fact that you're so torn up about it proves that you're the only person I trust in this world with this. You…" he swallows, cheeks turning pink. "You're good, Phainon. You're the best thing in this gods-damned world. And even if you stabbed me a thousand times, that wouldn't change."

And Phainon…

Phainon crumbles, foundations ripped asunder, bloodstained hands clutching at Mydei's body like it contains a piece of his own soul.

End Notes

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